

Why You Need a Financial Planner

By: Talon Rucker

The best time to plant a tree was 20 years ago, but the second-best time is today. Everyone knows they should be investing and saving for retirement, but do they? Are you? And, if you are, are you doing it effectively? Or, have you updated it?

My friend is 35 and finally ready to get serious about investing. When we ran the numbers, we realized that by waiting five years to start, he effectively traded a dream retirement for a modest one. When he sold his company, he also paid nearly 15% more in taxes than necessary.

I am a financial planner. Nearly every time I tell people what I do for my career, I usually get one of three responses. They either know all about it and say that's an awesome career path. Or they respond, "So you must like numbers" (gosh, I hate this response). Or, they say, "What is that?"

So, I respond with a rant about how it is a customer-facing role where I help clients with retirement, tax strategies, investments… and they fall asleep standing up.

But financial planning is so exciting! And if you don't think so, then hire me to do it for you.

I wrote this article with an audience of individuals who have a net worth of $150,000 to $10,000,000 in mind, but I expect any reader to benefit greatly.

In this article, I will convince you that you need a financial planner. I will share:

- What a financial planner does
- Resolve common concerns and questions about the industry
- Walk you through how to start your financial plan with a financial planner

What does a financial planner do?

The Basics

Simply put, a financial planner is the quarterback of your financial team and financial roadmap.

One of the financial planner's main roles is to gather the team and communicate with them so that you don't have to. They bring accountants to help with tax strategies, attorneys to help with estate planning (estate is the wealth you leave behind after death), brokers to help with investments, and insurance providers to help with insurance.

Then, they themselves help you create your financial plan to work towards retirement and develop your investment so you can enjoy the compounding effects of interest. Let's jump into the benefits of each of these for you.



Tax Strategies

Just last week, a colleague of mine was able to help a client who sold a business for $131 million bring their tax bill legally and ethically from an estimated $40 million down to $1.2 million. This is the power of strategic tax strategies that a financial planner and accountant can do for you.

How was he able to do this? He used Qualified Small Business Stock (QSBS), Grantor Charitable Lead Annuity Trusts (CLATs), conservation easements, real estate depreciation, and solar credits, among many other strategies. The best part of all of this is that you do not need to know anything about it!

How much more in taxes are you currently paying than you are required to? Your financial team can find out.

Investing

Compound interest is often referred to as the eighth wonder of the world. A financial planner can help you access this power.

Figure 1: Compounding $80,000 at 8%. This illustrates the effect of compound interest. The blue represents the principal (the original $80,000 invested), and the light green represents interest compounded at 8% for 30 years.

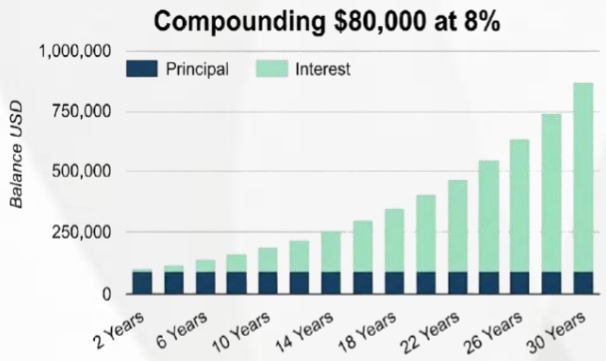


Figure 1 shows that with time and investment, $80,000 can become nearly $1,000,000 in 30 years. This proves the power of compound interest.

Now, let's say you gifted the $80,000, recorded in Figure 1, to your child when they were born. By the time they retired at 65, they would have over 14 million dollars! Funding an account like this is often entirely possible by using money you would have had to pay the government. Ask a financial planner how.

Retirement

A financial planner will not only help you access the power of compound interest for your retirement, but they will also help you with risk mitigation and adjusting.

I'll explain risk mitigation in this way: imagine all your investments were in stocks and you wanted to buy a home. But, right beforehand, the stock market dropped 20%. Having to sell investments for such an occasion during a dip in the stock market could be very costly. A financial planner will help you pick the proper investments at the proper time.

Putting money aside, a financial planner will also help you emotionally adjust to retirement. Depression rates skyrocket after retirement.

In the research article, "Association of depressive symptoms with retirement in Chinese employees", Fenglin Xu, Jingmin Yuan and Hongxia Wu tracked a group of 1,390 employees who were at least 45 years old and not yet retired in 2011. The study followed these same individuals across four "waves" of surveys (2011, 2013, 2015, and 2018).

The results of this study expressed a 1.5+ times higher rate of depression amongst retirees. Your financial planner has valuable experience helping clients transition into this phase of life.

Estate planning

Your estate is what you leave behind when you pass away. A financial planner combined with an attorney becomes the architect of your legacy. When you pass on after this life, your death tax could be anywhere between 4–40% of all that is owed to your heirs.

By working with professionals, you can mitigate those taxes, ensure a smooth transition of your assets, choose where your estate will end up, and avoid 18-month probate wait times for your family to access your will.

Most importantly, you will avoid the contention amongst family members if you leave a "ghost" of stress to haunt your family as they battle each other for their inheritance.

Insurance

A financial planner will help you view money through a new lens. That lens will help you see money as a means by which you can relieve stress so that you can better focus on the things that matter.

Figure 2: Disability Impact on Net Worth. This illustrates the effect that disability can have on a dual-income household with minimal insurance coverage. The faded green region is what the couple's net worth would be if they had disability insurance. The blue region is without insurance.



Figure 2 shows that without disability insurance, the couple can be drastically affected by an injury or health condition.

A financial planner can help you select the best insurance plan for you so that you can better sleep at night. These plans can protect your family from the effects of disability, health conditions, or loss of life.

Common Concerns/ Questions

I can do it myself

I love the initiative people take with their finances. I especially love people who do it themselves because they obviously value my career. But, is risking your life savings worth it?

Even just missing out on 1% can be the difference of thousands.

People who do it themselves often miss out on much more than 1%. They are also exposing themselves to many risks that experienced eyes can see.

The first risk: Your spouse. Estimates show that most divorces and arguments are rooted in financial burdens.

According to the surveys and studies by Jeffrey Dew, Sonya Britt, and Sandra Huston, in their 2012 publication, "Examining the Relationship Between Financial Issues and Divorce", finances were confirmed to be the leading root cause of divorce.

Having a mediator like a Financial Planner who knows your family well can be a huge help to your marriage. Choose a financial planner who keeps both spouses in the loop.

The second risk: Emotions. Often, the worst investment to buy is the one everyone is talking about because its price is high. Similarly, the worst time to sell a stock is when the market is doing poorly, and its price is low.

A Financial Planner acts as your emotional guardrail to keep you from making these counterintuitive decisions. A financial planner will be there to talk you straight when you're looking to make a decision that will cost you thousands.

A financial planner is not just someone you meet with before retirement

It is common for people to meet with a financial planner for the first time at age 38. Luckily, current trends are leading to younger generations meeting at 29. This is still much too late. Investments could have tripled or quadrupled within those nine years if they had started when they were 20.

Figure 3: The Impact of Starting Late. This demonstrates the impact that starting early can have on an investor's gains. The investors grow $250,000 at 8% respectively from the ages of 20, 30, and 40.

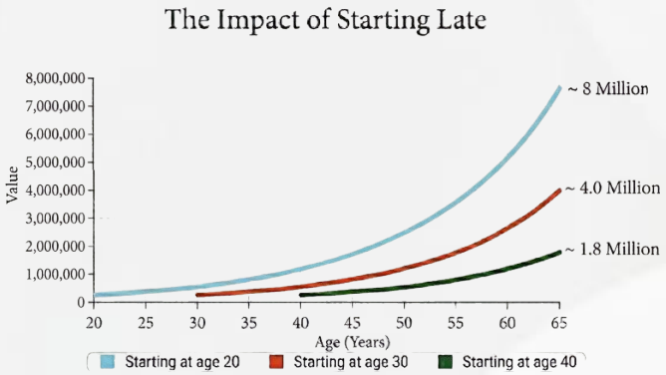


Figure 3 illustrates the dramatic compounding effect of starting young on wealth.

Meeting with a financial planner to invest as early as 20 is a great idea (or age 1 for that matter, make sure your kids have investment accounts). A financial planner would postpone much of the plan until the 20-year-old has built more wealth, but they would get them started with investments to help them collect on the power of compound interest.

What is a Certified Financial Planner?

CFP® stands for Certified Financial Planner. It is not a license; it is a designation. Think of it as kind of like a master's in financial planning.

A Certified Financial Planner needs to receive a bachelor's degree, take extra finance courses, sign a fiduciary ethics document, study for roughly 200-300 hours, pass a test with a 60% pass rate, and have 4000-6000 hours of experience in the field. They are then monitored to make sure their decisions are in the best interest of their clients. Why would this be important? Well, because they are handling your life savings.

How do financial planners get paid?



The industry is moving away from "selling products" and toward "selling advice."

- Fee-Only: The financial planner is paid only by AUM (Assets Under Management), usually charging roughly 1%.
- Fee-Based: Paid for both AUM and commission for products like insurance. This is the most common model and requires full disclosure of commissions.
- Commission-Only: They make money selling insurance or mutual funds. These are often not CFPs.

Starting Your Financial Plan

What do the meetings look like?

These meetings can take place in person or over video call. It is best to have both spouses in the meeting. They often take 45-90 minutes.

1. The First Meeting: A getting-to-know-you phase where you discuss what you care about most. You will then be given access to a Secure Portal to upload your current tax returns, pay stubs, and insurance policies.
2. The Second Meeting: A time to set measurable goals, like a house down payment or retirement income.
3. The Third Meeting: The financial planner runs your data through professional software and simulations.
4. The Fourth/Fifth Meeting: Your financial planner will simply walk you through a 20–50-page report. They will recommend specific strategies we discussed earlier in this article.
5. The Sixth Meeting: This is when you will finally take action by opening accounts.

After these initial meetings, meetings taper to 1-2 times a year for updating and monitoring, or as often as you would like.

Hopefully, you can see that financial planners are very careful about giving you the best plan. And note that some of these meetings may be with a specialist or an assistant.



How to get started

All you need to do now is make a call. Find three potential candidates using databases like the

CFP® Board's "Let's Make a Plan," NAPFA, the XY Planning Network, or ask a friend who they use.

Most planners offer a free 30-minute introduction Zoom call. On these calls, ask them questions like:

-"Are you a fiduciary 100% of the time?" (If they hedge or say "it depends," that's a red flag).

-"How exactly do you get paid?" (They should be able to explain their fee in one sentence).

-"Have you worked with people like me before?"

-"What is your communication style?" (Do they use a portal? Do they text? How often will you meet?)

Conclusion

A Final Note

Now the question. Can money buy happiness? Yes, yes it can, it can buy ice cream.

With all seriousness, money does bring happiness if you are already happy. But, money without happiness is like salt without food. Salt is a mineral not a spice. It enhances what is already there.

So, looking to the future and saying things like I will be happy when I have money is just false.

Money can make you happier. I don't think I need to convince you more of this.

The reverse is also true. Debt can make you very unhappy

My Invitation

So my invitation. Build wealth and use it for good. Be a good steward. Stay out of debt. And view money as a stress reliever.

As a review, a holistic Certified Financial Planner can benefit you and your finances using tax strategies, investments, retirement, insurance, and other methods. I have resolved concerns about doing it yourself and have explained how a financial planner can help you mitigate stress and be a blessing to your family. I have also shared what it looks like to meet with a financial planner and how to get started.

I am confident I have convinced you that a financial planner can help you. Although convincing you that you need a financial planner wasn't my real goal. My real goal was to get you to do something about it.

Remember, the best time to plant a tree was 20 years ago, but the second-best time is today.

I am happy to meet with you. You can reach me at (480) 589-2068 or by email talonrucker@gmail.com

About the Author



Talon Rucker is from Gilbert, AZ. He is driven, ambitious, and relentlessly optimistic. He has a Bachelor of Science in Finance from Brigham Young University – Marriott School of Business.

He is on track to secure his CFP®, Life and Health, SIE, Series 7, and Series 66.

Beyond academia and professional pursuits, he loves to ski and play tennis.

He is actively seeking opportunities to expand his horizons and contribute meaningfully to the field of finance. Connect to explore synergies and chart a course toward mutual success!

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